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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION MARCH 2025

SECOND SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG2DSCHIS100 - **THEMES IN GLOBAL HISTORY** (2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours Maximum Marks: 70

Part A

Short Answers - Answer any 10 questions, each question carries 2 marks

1. Define what is Genus. [K] / [CO1] – It is a biological taxonomic category – used to indicate common ancestry – Modern humans and predecessors belonged to *homo* genus – In biological classification genus occupies position above species and below family.

2. Recall the significance of Flake stone tools. [U] / [CO1] – Prehistoric stone tools crafted by removing flakes from core stone piece – found representations in the earliest stone tools industries – central to hominid technology representing ability in doing precision tasks, intentional designs, indicates foresight and cultural transmission.

3. Define what is Human Geography. [U] / [CO1] - Human geography examines the relationship between people and their environments, looking at how societies adapt to and shape their surroundings through cultural practices, economic activities, urban development, and responses to issues like climate change and migration. This field connects with related disciplines in social science to understand modern human-environment interactions.

4. Make a short note on the Feminist critique on ‘Man-the-Hunter Theory.’ [U] / [CO2] – Challenging the traditional depiction of early human societies where men were primarily hunters and women were primarily gatherers – critiqued as simplistic and biased view – arguments on the basis of evidences on women’s active participation in hunting, and highlight the importance of gathering, which provided a significant portion of the diet and was crucial for community survival.

5. Define what is 'Empire’. [K] / [CO4] - Empire is a political order that subjugates diverse cultural groups under unfixed, expansionist boundaries. Empires could unify disparate ethnicities and ecological zones, whether through conquest, voluntary alliances, or dynastic unions.

6. Define what is Monotheism. [K] / [CO2] – Belief in a single god – a recent stage in the evolution in religion and belief in god – usually associated with historic religions – god envisaged as an omnipotent and omnipresent entity

7. Recall the process of 'Quenching' in iron working. [K] / [CO2] – An accidentally invented process which significantly enhanced the quality of carburized iron – It is the quick cooling of a hot piece of metal by plunging it into water – Much harder microstructure called martensite could be achieved through this.

8. What is meant by Physical Violence? [K] / [CO4] - Physical violence is an act attempting to cause, or resulting in, pain and/or physical injury - War, murder, rape, torture, corporal punishment, even suicide, state sponsored violence et al are physical violence.

9. Define Bourgeoisie. [K] / [CO5] – Class of capitalists who have an exclusive possession of means of consumption, new raw materials and instruments necessary for production – economically dominant class formation following industrial revolution – They relied on commercial wealth rather than landed wealth – Marx called this class as 'town bred, mercantile, sober and industrious'. – control state apparatus and cultural production.

10. *Civilization and Capitalism.* [K] / [CO5] – work of Fernand Braudel - Focuses on the development of mechanisms of exchange - shops, markets, trade networks, and banking - in the pre-industrial stages of capitalism

11. What is meant by Classical Cholera. [K] / [CO1] – Among the seven major cholera outbreaks, the first six were called classical cholera - It refers to one of the two main biotypes of Vibrio cholerae, the bacterium that causes cholera, the other is El tor.

12. Dipesh Chakrabarty. [K] / [CO1] – Author of The Climate of History: Four Theses - He is noted for recent contribution towards planetary consciousness in history by opening new vistas like role of climate in history. He is a founding member of the editorial collective of *Subaltern Studies*, a consulting editor of *Critical Inquiry*, and a founding editor of *Postcolonial Studies.*

Part B

Short Essay - Answer any 6 questions, each question carries 5 marks

13. Outline the changes happened in human social life following the agricultural revolution. [U] / [CO1] - Agriculture forced humans to abandon their million-year-old foraging lifestyle and settle permanently near fields – Increase in violence in human society since the conquest for more lands for cultivation - Fifteen percent of total deaths and 25% of male deaths in agricultural societies were caused by violence - Cereals offered Homo sapiens more food per unit of territory and enabled them to multiply exponentially. This gave humans the ability to keep most people alive under worse conditions - Women began giving birth to children every year. The extra food produced was consumed by the growing population. The child mortality rate rose to one in every three births - Although agriculture placed more food at human disposal, the extra food translated into population explosion and pampered elites instead of better diet or more leisure. An average farmer had to work harder than an average forager and received a worse diet in return.

14. Explain the logic behind the imposition of European triad in time globally. [U] / [CO1] – Ancient, Medieval and Modern chronological triad took birth in Europe around the 16th and 17th century. European expansion throughout world in the form of trade, colonialism and intellectual influence carry their time notions too – Dark Age of Europe transferred to the rest of the world – European intellectual enlightenment as Modern too transferred to other parts of the globe- Branding other societies are still in Dark Age like conditions acted as a legitimization to European colonialism as a vehicle of modern civilization.

15. Explain the process of evolution and popularization of linear time framework. [U] / [CO1] – Linear time took origin from Semitic traditions where the direction of history is straight from creation to judgement day. A more precise and linear time acquired currency with the establishment of a state system with inscriptions, records, official documents, taxation, and the growth of grants and gifts by rulers, which required recording. The contemporary chronological notion of time was a product of secularization and scientific inquiry in the West. The Enlightenment concept of progress strengthened the idea of a forward movement of time. Linear time scheme became a more or less standard mode of reckoning and remembering events, and this mode has been universalized following European colonization. Chronological time in history is a homogeneous medium where all events have their definite place.

16. Examine the nature of labour under slavery in ancient Roman Empire. [E] / [CO4] – Slavery as a fundamental institution in Roman society – about 10-15% of population in the Empire was slaves- Substantial economic activity in Rome had been carried in this way by slaves and freedmen – Public work largely required their service - Prisoners of War, piracy, birth to enslaved mothers, debt and military campaign as the sources of slave – Legal status as property and not as person – master had near absolute power over slaves – head of the household had legal authority over household slaves – Types; urban household, agricultural, industrial, public and gladiators. Treatment varies depending on master, occupation and household - Manumission or granting freedom is relatively common -

17. Observe characteristic features of feudal mode of production. [U] / [CO2] – feudalism as European social formation following the decline of the Roman Empire – chief form of subsistence revolved around land - It is a hierarchical pyramidal organization of the society with various layers of political elements, characterized by scalar property and parcelization of sovereignty – Basic primary producers are tenants owning means of production or serfs – Apart from them, nobility and church constituted two other major constituents of feudal society – Landlords extracted surplus through extra economic extraction – Rent in feudalism often assume the nature of labour rent – hierarchical political structure is retained by fiefdom and ideological backup given by the church – Feudal hierarchy is based on service given to the immediate higher level and homage received from bottom level; called subinfeudation– Commodity production is under the tutelage of agriculture – Feudal economy is natural, agrarian and subsistence economy.

18. Analyse the concept of value in relation with commodity production. [An] / [CO5] - A commodity has two properties: use-value and exchange value. To become a commodity, a thing should first of all possess use-value. The fact that two different commodities can be exchanged is because there is something in common between them. Every commodity item is created by human labour. The value of a commodity is the human labour in general congealed in it. Therefore, what is common to, all commodities is value. The magnitude of the value in a commodity is determined by the amount of labour-time socially necessary for producing it. In exchanging commodities according to value, people actually exchange their own labour.

19. Critically examine the statement 'A state may consist of more than one nation'. [E] / [CO4] - A state is an institutional mechanism that has definite boundaries, population, government, and sovereignty. The concept of nation is a bit complex. It is never fixed/static. A tightly knit large group of people who are psychologically united and have some

homogeneity in culture. Cultural homogeneity is constituted of common language, institutions, religion, historical experience etc. While state is an institutional mechanism often assume hierarchical and materialist character nation is organic. Nation is something in a process of making or becoming – All nation states are emerged out of some other state system – national communities often imagined or invented their existence in the past – national communities in a state system expecting a new nation state/s renounce or negate present state apparatus. Secessionist movements in different parts of the globe is living example of 'A state may consist of more than one nation'.

20. How do scientists define the Anthropocene, and what are the key arguments for considering it a distinct geological epoch? [U] / [CO1] – Anthropocene is a distinct word to note the particular geological phase of our planet, different from Holocene or the warm phase after Ice Ages. With the technological achievements and growing consumption of resources, including fossil fuels, the world has entered into a new phase called Anthropocene, where humans have become a geological force. With the current rate of footprints, humans could inflict damage equivalent to the Great Extinction, which wiped out dinosaurs. Thus, humans as a force of nature in the geological sense pose a serious challenge to the division of history into natural history and human history. The name for this new geological age is Anthropocene, proposed by Nobel-winning chemist Paul J Crutzen and his collaborator Eugene F Stoermer in 2000. They located the beginning of the Anthropocene with the Industrial Revolution. However, the Great Acceleration or economic growth charged following the second world war has been pointed as the beginning of the Anthropocene. The amount of carbon di oxide in the atmosphere at present is equivalent that of the rate 25 million years ago. If it moves like todays rate, it will mark the wipe out of life in the earth.

21. Analyse the material milieu of the development of post-humanism. [U] / [CO3] – Human is a modern construct, shared by enlightenment philosophy - Reality created by artificial intelligence is torpedoing this modernist logic. It became inevitable that humans had to translate themselves to the new machine-organic complex - New imagination of human-machine combine emerged as a reality - Anxieties about human existence have been shared by international health organizations from 1980s onwards, especially in the background of the spread of zoonotic viruses from animals to humans. The uncertainties created by the unexpected COVID pandemic and other zoonotic diseases, the invasive effect of surveillance capitalism, interventions of the necro power (of the state), and the withdrawal of civil society set stage for post humanist thought in our times. The Great Acceleration created by neoliberalism threatens the very existence of human life with dignity – Emergence of biopolitics and panopticon surveillance of the state system threaten the liberal autonomous human concept – Algorithms emerged as invisible forces that determine everything.

22. What are the key differences between the gadgetization of humans and the humanization of gadgets? [U] / [CO3] - The concepts of gadgetization of humans and humanization of gadgets, as discussed by Lv Huang and Ruyao Huang, reflect two opposing yet interconnected responses to technological integration. Gadgetization refers to the process by which humans increasingly adapt their behaviours, cognition, and identities to fit within digital and automated systems, often at the cost of individuality and agency—as seen historically in industrial labour models like Taylorism and, more recently, in dependence on

smartphones and computers. In contrast, humanization involves designing machines, especially service robots, to exhibit human-like traits such as warmth and emotional responsiveness. This is intended to facilitate more natural and engaging human-machine interactions. While gadgetization alters humans to fit technology, humanization modifies technology to fit human social expectations, highlighting a dynamic tension in our relationship with machines.

Part C

Essay Questions - Answer any 2 questions, each question carries 10 marks

23. Examine the role of imaginative and narrative thoughts in the development of human species. [U] / [CO1] - Humans are the only minds in nature that have invented symbols - The difference between pre-symbolic cognition and symbol-driven cognition created a huge gap between human culture and the rest of the animal kingdom - Only humans have self-initiated access to memory or autocuing or the ability to recall specific memories independent of environment - Humans have extraordinarily large brains compared to other animals – Three cognitive revolution occurred as part of human evolution; the first happened about 1.5 million years ago, radical improvement in human motor control—the talent for using the whole body as a communication device or body skill called pure mimesis; the second breakthrough happened about 0.5 to 0.1 million years ago when vocal tracts evolved for languages. Enable narrative thought or storytelling and can lift listener outside of space and time. Human got the capacity for inventing and retrieving thousands of lexical items. The third major cognitive breakthrough, the externalization of memory, occurred around 20,000 years ago. This phase is associated with 'literacy'. The language of humans can produce an infinite number of sentences with distinct meanings using a limited number of sounds and signs. Language evolved as a means of sharing information about the world. Humans could now gossip for hours on end. Reliable and trusted information facilitated the creation of larger bands and ensured cooperation. Only Homo sapiens can talk about entities they have never seen, touched, or smelled. The ability to speak about fiction is the most unique feature of sapiens language.

24. Discuss the ecological impact of iron smelting in the ancient world. [An] / [CO2] - Iron tools dramatically altered landscapes through deforestation and changed land use patterns - Central Africa experienced a "Late Holocene Rainforest Crisis" (6th-1st century BCE) where Bantu iron users cleared forest areas equivalent to the size of the United States - Chinese iron smelting (from 700 BCE) led to extensive agricultural expansion, deforestation, and contributed to Yellow River floods (3.4 lakh lives lost in 1642 flood) - British forests declined severely - from rich diversity 7500 years ago to only 15% coverage by the 11th century due to agriculture and metallurgy - Iron production required enormous wood resources: 80kg wood needed per 1kg of iron; 18th century blast furnaces used 12,000 tons of wood for 300 tons of iron; A single 16th century Sussex furnace consumed 8 square kilometers of forest annually - The Mehrauli iron pillar (6,098kg) required approximately 4.88 lakh kg of wood - equivalent to 900 sala trees or 12,200 babool trees - Military metallurgy had massive environmental impact: Mauryan army's equipment (3,450 tons of iron) required cutting approximately 6.9 million trees - Increased warfare meant intensified

wood consumption - Additional metal uses (agriculture, construction, sculpture, coinage) further accelerated deforestation and environmental change

25. Observe the technological advancement achieved in the fields of iron and coal during the Industrial Revolution. [U] / [CO5] – Abraham Darby (Coal Brookdale) pioneered using coke instead of charcoal in blast furnaces - Wood Brothers (1760s) reduced sulphur and phosphorous contamination using clay pots to separate pig iron from coal - Henry Cort (1784) developed puddling and rolling processes, improving iron production - Henry Bessemer (1856) patented steel production directly from molten pig iron - Thomas steel process neutralized phosphorous, enhancing steel quality - Railways were the first major customers for new steel - Thomas steel enabled production of general iron, wire, tubes, pipes, and sheet metal - Shipyards became major customers for high-quality steel - Steel industry became symbolic of national strength - Coal as new source of energy and economizing fuel consumption- Steam engine and steel industry were thrived over coal power. English model of coal consumption has been copied by all other European industrial nations. Britain's coal output enhanced from 6 million in 1770 to 12 million in 1800 and to 57 million in 1861.

26. Critically evaluate the character of nationalism in India. [E] / [CO4] - Indian nationalism has been identified in at least seven ways. There are problems with each of these characterizations. The identifications are; (1) an ancient civilizational entity (often neglect the historical role of colonialism in political unification); (2) a composite culture (reduced the narratives to Hindu-Muslim and neglect the diverse cultural belief patterns); (3) a multi-national polity (often identified religious groups as the multi in national framework); (4) a religious entity (a communal interpretation of nationalism); (5) a geographical/ territorial entity populated by a multiplicity of religious communities; (6) a collectively of linguistic communities; and finally as (7) a unity of great and little nationalisms. Anti-colonial nature of Indian nationalism during Freedom Movement – A concept of great nationalism emerged in contrast to little nationalism of the regions - Independent India has witnessed two types of nationalism: state-centred and state-renouncing nationalism. Secessionist movements often found source in identity seeking ethnic movements – Nationalism is working in tandem with the identification of the Other.